



**NOW WE ARE ONTO THE COMMERCIAL SPACE. THIS [COMMERCIAL ORBITAL] MISSION WILL PROVE REUSABILITY [OF LAUNCH VEHICLES] FOR US"**

**SRINATH RAVICHANDRAN**

Co-founder and CEO, Agnikul Cosmos

"Governments have played a major role in sustaining every successful private launch company. You can see this across advanced spacefaring nations. This is how the ecosystem works. We exist because ISRO built the foundation that makes a private launch industry possible," he explains.

Skyroot Aerospace raised nearly \$60 million in a funding round in May to become India's first spacetechnic unicorn with a pre-money valuation of \$1.1 billion.

## AGNIKUL COSMOS

**W**HEN SRINATH RAVICHANDRAN, Co-founder and CEO of Agnikul Cosmos, was growing up in Chennai in early 2000, he wanted to become an aerospace engineer. But with few opportunities in India's space sector at the time, he took a more conventional path, studying electrical engineering instead. After working in India for a few years, he moved to the US, driven by a desire to make money on Wall Street, where he spent nearly a decade in finance. Yet, despite the successful career, Ravichandran realised that his heart is still in aerospace. He went back to school for a second master's degree—this time in aerospace engineering—and even before graduating, relocated to Los Angeles, the heart of the space-tech industry. Convinced that India could build this future, Ravichandran returned home to start Agnikul Cosmos, a space-tech start-up that aims to make rocket launches for small satellites commercially viable. He roped in rocket scientist Satyanarayanan Chakravathy from IIT Madras. Co-founder Moin SPM used to run a contract manufacturing business in Chennai.

"The idea was to enable small satellites to go to space efficiently. We set out on a journey to build new technologies for this," Ravichandra tells *BT*. "What we quickly realised was that existing technologies of rocketry were optimised for larger rockets, so we couldn't apply that directly to smaller rockets," he adds.

Agnikul Cosmos, which has raised \$60 million so far, completed its first test mission in May 2024 to demonstrate everything that it built. "Now we are onto the commercial space. It will happen by early next year," says Ravichandran.

Like SpaceX pioneered reusability for big rockets, Agnikul wants to do it for smaller rockets.

Agnikul's first commercial orbital mission, which it expects to undertake as early as next year, will carry customer satellites while also attempting to recover the rocket's first stage and keep the upper stage operational in orbit, marking the company's first step towards reusable launch vehicles. "This mission will prove reusability for us," says Ravichandra, adding that no company has attempted recovery yet.

In 2024, the IIT Madras-incubated start-up launched the world's first rocket with a single piece 3D printed engine from Sriharikota with the help of IN-SPaCE and ISRO.